

THE STYLING LESSON

The perfect imperfect

Two of the seven Zen principles come together in the autumn room. *Wabi-sabi* — the beauty of the worn, the aged, the impermanent. And *fukinsei* — the rightness of asymmetry, of the deliberately off-balance. Together they are the cure for the one thing that kills a calm room: the matched, the perfect, the showroom.

So buy the stoneware where no two plates are alike. Keep the bowl with the chip you remember. Hang the print off-centre, not floating in the middle of the wall. Group your objects in threes, never in symmetrical pairs. Let the wood show its grain and the linen show its creases. The aim is not mess — it is the studied, gentle irregularity of things made and used by hand, which reads as *alive* where perfect matching reads as *bought*.

"Perfect is what a showroom looks like. Imperfect is what a home feels like."

